

**HUNTING BY STEALTH**

The common boa will sit and wait, watching its prey from a suitable vantage point. Timing its strike to perfection, it lunges forward and seizes its victim in its jaws before wrapping itself around it. The snake then asphyxiates its prey by tightly squeezing it—a process that can be so quick that small animals may be killed in seconds.

*Boa constrictor***Common boa**

**Location** Central America, South America, some Caribbean islands



**Length** 3½–13 ft (1–4 m)  
**Breeding** Viviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial/Arboreal  
**Status** Not evaluated

A large snake, with a narrow head and a pointed snout, the common boa varies in color (see right) but has dark, saddle markings along the back, sometimes becoming dark red toward the tail. There may be as many as 10 subspecies (see right). The common boa is very adaptable, and uses a huge range of habitats, from tropical forest to dry savanna. It may also be found in urban areas. It climbs well but may equally hunt on the ground, especially in some of the drier habitats in which it occurs (here, it may estivate in order to survive the worst heat of the summer months). It is also an able swimmer and often takes to the water voluntarily. Secretive, and fairly

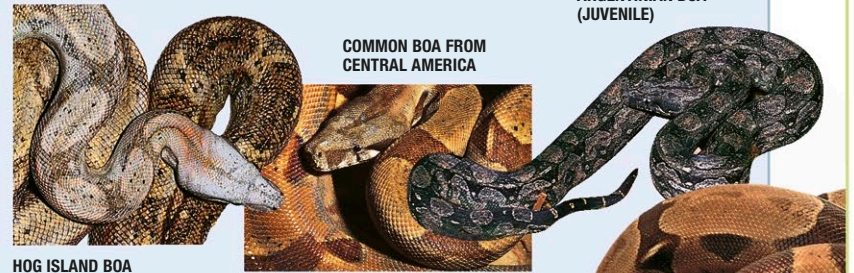
**CONCEALING COLORS**

The colors and patterns seen in the common boa serve a valuable purpose—helping to break up the snake's outline and enabling it to disappear into its surroundings.

sluggish in behavior, it may be active by day or by night, depending on the climate. It preys on a wide variety of mammals and birds—suffocating them with its muscular coils before swallowing them whole.

**COMMON BOA SUBSPECIES**

The many subspecies of the common boa vary considerably in size and color. Dwarf island races, such as the Hog Island boa, may be only 3¼ ft (1 m) long, while mainland boas are typically 9¼ ft (3 m)—although in exceptional cases some reach 13 ft (4 m). The color ranges from mainly black (Argentinian boa) or olive-green (Central American boa) to the much lighter, pinkish or silver-gray specimens (Hog Island boa), often with a markedly contrasting tail. All, however, have distinctive saddle markings.



HOG ISLAND BOA

COMMON BOA FROM CENTRAL AMERICA

ARGENTINIAN BOA (JUVENILE)



characteristic saddle markings

dark stripe behind each eye

**GIVING BIRTH**

Depending on the subspecies (here, a red-tail boa), common boas may produce 6–50 young in a litter, each 14–23½ in (35–60 cm) long. The newborn snakes fend for themselves immediately after breaking through the soft membrane that surrounds them at birth.